

01 · THE SERIES

COACHES ARE PEOPLE

WHY COACHES DO WHAT THEY DO



UNDERSTANDING THE PERSON BEHIND THE DECISIONS CHANGES EVERYTHING.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Why Coaches Do What They Do

← You are here

02

The Coachability Equation

Coming up.

03

What Coaches Actually See

Coming up.

04

The Athlete's Role in the Dynamic

Coming up.

05

How to Change the Dynamic

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

COACHES ARE
OVERWORKED,
UNDERPAID, AND
UNDERRESOURCED.
AND THEY'RE MAKING
DECISIONS ANYWAY.

Most coaches are doing more than anyone sees. Understanding their reality changes how you interpret their decisions.

— CONTEXT CHANGES INTERPRETATION

THE COACH'S REALITY

WHAT NO ONE TELLS YOU ABOUT COACHING YOUTH SPORTS.

→ Most coaches are juggling 12+ athletes with different needs, personalities, and readiness levels

→ They are giving their time, energy, and expertise often for very little compensation

→ The capacity to give every athlete exactly what they need doesn't exist at this level

— MOST COACHES CARE. MOST ARE STRETCHED. BOTH CAN BE TRUE.

HOW COACHES PRIORITIZE

LIMITED BANDWIDTH

With 12+ athletes, coaches gravitate toward the ones who make their limited time feel worth it.



THE COACHABILITY VARIABLE

The athlete who responds to feedback creates an efficient loop. The one who doesn't breaks it.

SUBCONSCIOUS GRAVITY

Coaches aren't always aware they're doing this. It's human and it's fixable.

06 · WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR ATHLETE

THE OPPORTUNITY

SHE HAS CONTROL

How a coach perceives your athlete is heavily influenced by how your athlete behaves.

THE SYSTEM IS PREDICTABLE

Once you understand what coaches respond to, you can train for it.

NOT ABOUT TALENT

The most coachable athlete often gets more out of a season than the most talented one.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

A COACH WHO SEEMS
UNFAIR MIGHT JUST
BE A STRETCHED PERSON
GRAVITATING TOWARD
WHAT MAKES THE WORK
FEEL POSSIBLE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— CONTEXT CHANGES EVERYTHING

THIS WEEK

BUILD CONTEXT THIS WEEK.

- ✓ Name three things you know about your coach's reality outside of practice.
- ✓ Identify one way your athlete currently makes the coach's job harder without realizing it.
- ✓ Identify one way she makes it easier.
- ✓ Think about what it would look like to show up in a way that makes the coach want to invest in her more.



COACHES ARE PEOPLE

THE COACHABILITY EQUATION

02

THE ATHLETE WHO IS EASIER TO COACH GETS MORE OUT OF EVERY SEASON.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE TECHNICALLY WEAKER
ATHLETE WHO IS COACHABLE
GETS MORE REPS,
MORE TRUST, AND
MORE OPPORTUNITY
THAN THE STRONGER
ONE WHO ISN'T.

This sounds unfair until you understand the system. Then it's actually predictable and trainable.

— COACHABILITY IS A MULTIPLIER

THE COACHABILITY EQUATION

Coachability multiplies talent. Uncoachability cancels it.

→ Coachable athlete: receives feedback, shows attempt to apply it, makes the coach feel heard

→ Uncoachable athlete: receives feedback, shows no visible response, coach stops investing

→ The loop: more investment → more reps → more growth → more playing time

— TALENT GETS YOU IN THE ROOM. COACHABILITY KEEPS YOU THERE.

05 · WHAT COACHABILITY IS

THE THREE SIGNALS

VISIBLE ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

She doesn't have to agree. She has to show she heard it.



APPLIED ATTEMPT

She tries what the coach asked even imperfectly in the next rep.

NON-DEFENSIVE RESPONSE

When she makes a mistake, she resets forward instead of explaining backward.



COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS

IT'S NOT PERFECTION

Being coachable doesn't mean executing everything immediately.

IT'S NOT COMPLIANCE

Asking thoughtful questions is coachable. Arguing every call isn't.

IT'S NOT TALENT

The least athletic player on a roster can be the most coachable. Those are separate.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO
MAKES HER COACH FEEL
HEARD WILL GET MORE
OUT OF THIS SEASON
THAN THE ONE WHO
MAKES HER COACH
WORK FOR IT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— COACHABILITY IS A MULTIPLIER

THIS WEEK

ASSESS YOUR ATHLETE'S COACHABILITY THIS WEEK.

- ✓ Ask her coach privately: what does coachability look like from your seat?
- ✓ Observe your athlete during the next practice specifically for the three signals.
- ✓ Ask your athlete: when you receive feedback from coach, what's your first instinct?
- ✓ Identify one coachability habit to build together based on what you find.



COACHES ARE PEOPLE

WHAT COACHES
ACTUALLY SEE

03

THE VIEW FROM THE BENCH IS BUILT ON PATTERNS, NOT MOMENTS.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

COACHES DON'T EVALUATE
A MOMENT.
THEY FILE PATTERNS.
AND PATTERNS BECOME
DECISIONS.

What a coach thinks of your athlete was built over dozens of practices, not one game.

— PATTERNS ARE THE PRODUCT

THE PATTERN LIBRARY

WHAT COACHES ARE BUILDING IN THEIR HEAD ABOUT EVERY ATHLETE.

- Response to feedback: does she try to apply it or does it disappear?
- Behavior under pressure: does she manage herself or look for external help?
- Practice energy: does she bring it consistently or only when she feels like it?

— THE PATTERN LIBRARY IS WHAT DETERMINES PLAYING TIME NOT THE LAST MATCH.

05 · THE PATTERNS THAT COST

WHAT BUILDS THE WRONG FILE

INCONSISTENCY

High effort sometimes, low effort other times coaches can't build trust on a variable.



EXTERNAL DEPENDENCY

Looking to the stands, parents in the coach's ear, emotional reactions that need management.

FEEDBACK AVOIDANCE

Physically present but mentally unavailable for coaching.



06 · REWRITING THE PATTERN

HOW TO CHANGE THE FILE

IT TAKES A FULL SEASON

One good week doesn't reset a bad pattern. Consistent behavior over time does.

START AT PRACTICE

The pattern file is mostly built there, not at matches.

NAME IT TOGETHER

Help your athlete understand what pattern she's currently building and what one she wants to build instead.

02



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

A GREAT GAME
DON'T BUILD A SEASON.
A GREAT PATTERN
BUILDS A CAREER.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— PATTERNS ARE THE PRODUCT



THIS WEEK

MAP YOUR ATHLETE'S CURRENT PATTERN.

- ✓ In the next two practices, watch for the three pattern signals.
- ✓ Ask your athlete: what pattern do you think your coach would say you're building right now?
- ✓ Ask what pattern she wants to build.
- ✓ Identify one specific practice behavior to change that would shift the coach's file in the right direction.



01 · THE SERIES

COACHES ARE PEOPLE

THE ATHLETE'S ROLE IN THE DYNAMIC



THE DYNAMIC BETWEEN ATHLETE AND COACH IS NOT FIXED. IT'S SHAPED BY THE ATHLETE.



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How to Change the Dynamic

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HEAR THIS ONCE

YOUR ATHLETE HAS
MORE CONTROL
OVER THIS RELATIONSHIP
THAN SHE THINKS.

The coach isn't doing things to her. The athlete's behavior is shaping the coach's response in ways that are entirely predictable.

— THE ATHLETE SHAPES THE DYNAMIC

THE FEEDBACK LOOP

WHAT THE ATHLETE DOES CREATES WHAT THE COACH DOES.

→ Athlete is coachable → coach invests more → athlete gets more → athlete improves

→ Athlete is uncoachable → coach pulls back → athlete gets less → athlete stagnates

→ The loop is started by the athlete always

— CHANGE THE INPUT. CHANGE THE OUTPUT.

05 · TAKING OWNERSHIP

WHERE THE ATHLETE HAS POWER

FEEDBACK RESPONSE

How she responds in the 10 seconds after feedback is the most powerful signal she sends.

PRACTICE CONSISTENCY

Bringing the same energy to every rep not just the ones she's excited about.

NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Eye contact, posture, energy the coach reads all of it as a signal about readiness.



06 · THE CONVERSATION TO HAVE

WITH YOUR ATHLETE

NOT: 'WHAT IS YOUR COACH DOING?'

This frames her as a passive recipient of the coach's choices.

INSTEAD: 'WHAT ARE YOU CURRENTLY BUILDING WITH YOUR COACH?'

This frames her as an active participant in the dynamic.

THE SHIFT

From 'what is happening to me' to 'what am I creating' is the most important mindset change in youth sports.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SHE IS NOT A PASSIVE
RECIPIENT OF HER
COACH'S DECISIONS.
SHE IS AN ACTIVE
ARCHITECT OF THE
RELATIONSHIP.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE ATHLETE SHAPES THE DYNAMIC

THIS WEEK

HAVE THE OWNERSHIP CONVERSATION THIS WEEK.

- ✓ Ask your athlete: what do you think you're currently building with your coach?
- ✓ Ask: what would you do differently in the next 2 weeks to change that dynamic?
- ✓ Give her one specific thing to try not a lecture, one action.
- ✓ Follow up after 2 weeks: what did she try? What changed?



COACHES ARE PEOPLE

HOW TO CHANGE THE DYNAMIC

OS

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN AN ATHLETE AND COACH CAN BE REBUILT — FROM THE ATHLETE'S SIDE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE DYNAMIC CAN
ALWAYS BE REBUILT.
BUT IT HAS TO START
WITH THE ATHLETE.

Parents can't fix this from the outside. Athletes can change it entirely from the inside.

— REBUILD FROM THE INSIDE

THE REBUILD SEQUENCE

FROM THE ATHLETE'S SIDE OF THE COURT.

→ Week 1: change one feedback response visible acknowledgement, every single time

→ Week 2: add applied attempt try the instruction in the very next rep

→ Week 3: bring consistent practice energy same effort, every drill, every day

— THREE WEEKS OF DIFFERENT BEHAVIOR STARTS TO REWRITE THE COACH'S FILE.

05 · FOR THE PARENT

YOUR ROLE IN THE REBUILD

STAY OUT OF IT

Do not contact the coach during the rebuild. Let the athlete's behavior speak.

COACH THE PROCESS

Help her practice the feedback response at home not to coach her volleyball, but to practice the skill.

CELEBRATE THE REPS

Every time she executes a coachability behavior, name it. Build the identity around it.



06 · WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

THE TIMELINE

3 WEEKS

The coach begins to notice a pattern shift. The file starts to update.

6 WEEKS

Trust builds. Investment increases. The athlete gets more feedback which means more growth.

FULL SEASON

The dynamic has fundamentally changed. The athlete owns the outcome.

02

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE COACH CANNOT
GIVE BACK WHAT
THE ATHLETE HAS
TO EARN.
START EARNING.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— START FROM THE INSIDE



THIS WEEK

LAUNCH THE THREE-WEEK REBUILD.

✓ Week 1: commit to one visible acknowledgement after every piece of feedback at practice.

✓ Week 2: add an applied attempt try the instruction in the very next rep.

✓ Week 3: bring identical energy to every drill regardless of how she's feeling that day.

✓ At week 4: ask your athlete has anything changed in how the coach is responding?

